



*A Cup Of Compassion*

A CUP OF COMPASSION® SERIES · BOOK ONE

# The Benefit of Having Compassion

A Compassion Guide

**PAMELLA FOSTER-GREAR**

AUTHOR · LEGACY ADVOCATE · COMPASSION EDUCATOR

KEEP ON GIVING. KEEP ON BEING.



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Scripture quotations are from the King James Version.

This illustrated edition was created under the publisher's art direction for the A Cup of Compassion® series.

## **Important wellness notice**

This book shares the author's personal experiences and reflections. References to herbs, scent, and essential oils are offered for general and inspirational interest only. They are not medical advice and are not intended to diagnose, treat, cure, or prevent any disease. Consult a licensed healthcare professional before using herbs or essential oils, especially if you are pregnant or nursing, take medication, manage a health condition, have allergies or asthma, or are considering use around children or animals. Follow product directions. Do not ingest an essential oil unless a qualified professional specifically directs you to do so.

## **Dedication**

For my mother, Pastor Foster - who fed the street, prayed for the block, and never once called it sacrifice.

*Keep on giving. Keep on being.*

## The Series

1. *The Benefit of Having Compassion*
2. *Are You Born in Compassion or Nurtured in It?*
3. *Compassion and Legacy*
4. *Compassion and Confusion*
5. *Compassion and Companionship*
6. *Compassion, Commitment, and Confinement*

**BUILD IT. DOCUMENT IT. PASS IT ON.**

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# Introduction

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THE QUESTION BENEATH THE WORK



Many people have been asked whether we are born with compassion or nurtured in it. The deeper question is why it matters.

The purpose of this book is simple: all of us need to be treated with compassion, and all of us can learn to offer it. Compassion works the way faith works. A small beginning can move something that once looked immovable.

*“If ye have faith as a grain of mustard seed ... nothing shall be impossible unto you.”*

**MATTHEW 17:20, KJV**

Believing that we can change the world where we stand changes the way we move through it. Compassion gives feet to our beliefs. It turns concern into action for someone who needs comfort, help, attention, or a simple act of kindness.

I want to share how I found compassion and how it has blessed me across many years of my life. Scripture says that the Lord is “merciful and gracious, slow to anger, and plenteous in mercy” (Psalm 103:8, KJV). Chapter Five gathers more examples of that compassion in action.

## **Where mine came from**

My compassion was nurtured by my mother. I watched her carry the work of raising seven stair-step children. My father was around when it was convenient for him, but after he remarried, he did not nurture us. We were all still very young when he left.

Looking back, I can only wonder how my mother got through the hard years. I know now that her Christian faith carried her. Over time, she endured the loss of children to murder, drugs, disease, anger, and life itself. Yet by the grace of God, she kept moving through struggle, disappointment, and grief until she reached the age of ninety-six.

Her peace and determination in critical situations gave me the strength I have today. What I remember most is the love and compassion she brought to every challenge.



Whether compassion begins as temperament, is nurtured through example, or grows out of hardship, each of us has to practice it. We build love and affinity by paying attention, listening well, and choosing to make the world immediately around us more humane.

Thank you, Mom.

# One: The Philosophy of Compassion

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COMPASSION BEGINS WITH ATTENTION

Compassion is ethical and spiritual generosity. It is the gift of time, attention, and concern to another person. It notices the physical, mental, or emotional weight someone is carrying and responds with care.

It is related to empathy, but it does not stop at feeling. Empathy helps us imagine another person's experience. Compassion asks what loving action is possible now. That action may be a meal, a ride, a phone call, a boundary, a prayer, a practical resource, or the patience to listen without rushing to repair what we have not yet understood.

There are many signs that someone is hurting. We miss them when we are distracted, hurried, or determined to make the conversation about ourselves. Often, the first compassionate act is to slow down long enough to notice.

## The example I was given

As a child of six or seven, I did not know what I was seeing in my mother. I did not yet have the language to name it, even when other people met me without it. Now I know: it was compassion, kindness, faith, hope, and love. For the rest of my life, wherever I am allowed, I will practice it.

Some people will receive kindness. Others will refuse help of any kind. Do what you can, and remember that compassion does not mean controlling another person's response.

I learned by tagging along at my mother's dress hem, watching as she prayed for friends, loved ones, and strangers. She served as a pastor in our community for more than forty years. She was always being called on.

During those years, she also became a Head Start director at the Catholic Diocese up the street. She taught children and helped their parents. She fed neighbors and sent families home with food from the schoolroom. During the week she served children; on weekends she preached.

Decades later, I still hear from grandmothers who were once those children. They remember the Easter speeches, the children's choir, the first bench where the elders could keep watch, and the food Pastor Foster made sure they ate before going home.

My mother's compassion became more than a memory. The stability she built, including the real estate she later passed to her children, helped support businesses and opportunities for my siblings, nieces, and nephews. Her love reached forward.

### **Pour the cup: a three-part practice**

- 1. Notice.** Who near you seems rushed, quiet, overwhelmed, or unseen?
- 2. Listen.** Ask one sincere question and let the answer arrive without interruption.
- 3. Act.** Offer one specific form of help you can actually provide.

Compassion is not a performance. A small, dependable action is often more loving than a dramatic promise.

# Two: Becoming Compassionate

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A LIFE SHAPED BY REPEATED CHOICES

What does it mean to live with compassion?

In a community, it can be volunteering at a local school, checking on an elder, supporting a caregiver, or making sure a hungry family knows where to find help. At work, compassion can mean creating a supportive environment, giving useful feedback without humiliation, or helping a colleague finish an urgent task.

The most basic expression of compassion is care for people who cannot safely do everything for themselves: children, elders, people living with illness or disability, and loved ones moving through grief, abuse, loneliness, or poverty. It also extends to the animals that depend on us.

Compassion grows through repetition. We become compassionate by practicing patience when we are tired, curiosity when we are tempted to judge, and courage when care requires us to speak.

## Creating a personal cue

For me, herbs and aroma have sometimes served as reminders to slow down and return to intention. A familiar scent can become a cue: pause, breathe, pray, and remember the kind of presence you want to bring into the room.

This is a reflective practice, not a remedy. Essential oils are concentrated substances and should be handled with care. If you use them, follow the manufacturer's directions, avoid the eyes and broken skin, keep them away from children and animals, and ask a qualified healthcare professional about personal risks. Oil and water do not safely combine simply by shaking a bottle, so this book does not recommend homemade water sprays.

You do not need a product to practice this pause. A cup of tea, a favorite chair, a meaningful verse, or three quiet breaths can do the same work. The object is not the source of compassion. It is simply a reminder to return to it.

### **Pour the cup: the five-minute return**

- 1.** Place both feet on the floor and relax your shoulders.
- 2.** Take five unhurried breaths.
- 3.** Name what you feel without condemning yourself for feeling it.
- 4.** Ask, “What would kindness require in the next five minutes?”
- 5.** Choose one action that respects both the other person and your own limits.

# Three: Why Compassionate Giving Can Be Healing

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CARE FOR OTHERS WITHOUT ABANDONING YOURSELF



There is widespread burnout among healthcare providers, customer service workers, public employees, hospitality staff, caregivers, families, and neighbors. Long hours, financial strain, community violence, illness, grief, and constant exposure to screens and distressing news can make human connection feel like one more demand.

When the load stays heavy for too long, people may begin to withdraw. We speak less directly, listen less patiently, and assume we do not have enough time for ourselves, much less anyone else.

## Compassion in leadership

Leaders shape the emotional climate of a workplace and community. They influence how people are treated, whose needs are noticed, and whether purpose can survive pressure. Leadership by ego, anger, or



unexamined pain carries a cost: trust declines, people leave, and those with the least power absorb the most harm.

Compassionate leadership is not the absence of standards. It is clarity without cruelty. It asks what happened, what is needed, what accountability requires, and how dignity can remain intact through the process.

## **The voice inside**

Many people carry a running self-criticism built on shame: *I am not good enough. I do not have what it takes. I do not deserve help. I will always be alone.* Sometimes those messages begin inside us. Often, we take them on from other people.

Self-compassion means meeting difficulty with care and understanding rather than automatic condemnation. Researcher Kristin Neff commonly describes self-compassion through three connected ideas: self-kindness, a sense of common humanity, and mindful awareness. The purpose is not to excuse harmful behavior. It is to create enough steadiness to face reality, make repair, and choose a wiser next step.

Compassion for other people also needs boundaries. Without rest, honesty, and shared responsibility, giving can turn into resentment or exhaustion. Healthy compassion can say yes, no, not now, or I can help you find someone better equipped.

## **Herbs for the table and the heart**

Cooking can be a form of care. Basil, oregano, thyme, mint, dill, and cilantro bring aroma, color, and flavor to a shared table. A meal prepared with attention can say what words sometimes cannot: *You matter. I expected you. There is a place for you here.*

Use herbs as food and as part of tradition, not as substitutes for medical care. The healing in a shared meal may be the welcome, the conversation, and the dignity of being served.

### **Pour the cup: replace the inner sentence**

Write down one harsh sentence you repeat to yourself. Then replace it with a sentence that is truthful, accountable, and kind.

Instead of *I always fail*, try: *This did not go the way I hoped. I can learn what happened and choose my next step.*

Speak to yourself in a way that leaves room for growth.

# Four: Moving Pain with Compassion

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TURNING EXPERIENCE INTO SERVICE

I have learned a great deal about compassion inside marriage and long friendships. Many people will not give us a second chance, but we can still choose who we become. The love inside us does not have to be determined by what another person refuses to give.

Compassion does not erase consequences, and forgiveness does not require continued access. Sometimes care looks like reconciliation. Sometimes it looks like distance, safety, and prayer from the other side of a boundary.

## What pain taught me

Anxiety became a significant factor in my life after a frightening medical experience. I went into surgery because ovarian cancer was suspected. Afterward, I learned that cancer had not been confirmed. I was left with questions about how my symptoms were understood and with the long work of recovering from a procedure I had believed was necessary.

For years, the pain remained close. What began to move it was not a perfect explanation or apology. It was turning outward: supporting other people, sharing what I had learned about wellness, and helping someone else feel less alone. Service did not change the past. It changed what the past was allowed to produce in me.

## The power of a brief moment

Physicians Stephen Trzeciak and Anthony Mazzairelli have written about research showing that compassion can be communicated in less time than many busy professionals assume. A short statement of

concern, offered with full attention, can change how a person experiences an encounter.

Forty seconds is not a magic number, and compassion is not a script. The lesson is that meaningful presence does not always require an hour. A call, a note, a visit, or a sentence such as *I can see this is hard, and I want to understand what you need* can make room for dignity.

Thank God my mother taught us her own version of that practice more than sixty years ago.

### **Pour the cup: forty seconds of presence**

The next time someone shares a difficulty, do not immediately compare it with your own story. For forty seconds:

- face the person or give the call your full attention;
- name what you heard;
- ask what kind of support would help;
- make no promise you cannot keep.

# Five: The Word of God Calls Us to Compassion

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## NOTICE WHO IS STANDING BEFORE HIM

The Bible treats compassion as a mark of Christian character. Read these passages slowly and notice who is standing before Jesus each time.

*“And Jesus had compassion on them, and touched their eyes: and immediately their eyes received sight, and they followed him.”*

**MATTHEW 20:34, KJV**

Who among us needs to be seen beyond sickness or limitation?

*“Then Jesus called his disciples unto him, and said, I have compassion on the multitude, because they continue with me now three days, and have nothing to eat: and I will not send them away fasting, lest they faint in the way.”*

**MATTHEW 15:32, KJV**

Who is hungry or without a safe place to rest?

*“But when he saw the multitudes, he was moved with compassion on them, because they fainted, and were scattered abroad, as sheep having no shepherd.”*

**MATTHEW 9:36, KJV**

Who is young, vulnerable, or without trustworthy guidance?

*“And Jesus went forth, and saw a great multitude, and was moved with compassion toward them, and he healed their sick.”*

**MATTHEW 14:14, KJV**

Who in our community is carrying illness, fear, or exhaustion?

*“And when the Lord saw her, he had compassion on her, and said unto her, Weep not.”*

**LUKE 7:13, KJV**

He saw a widow walking behind her son’s coffin. Who is grieving in plain sight while the world keeps moving?

*“And Jesus, moved with compassion, put forth his hand, and touched him, and saith unto him, I will; be thou clean.”*

**MARK 1:41, KJV**

Who has been labeled untouchable: a returning citizen, a person living with addiction, a neighbor marked by poverty, or anyone a community has decided not to see?

Compassion asks us to look again.

### **Pour the cup: scripture into action**

Choose one passage from this chapter. Write down:

1. who was seen;
2. what need was present;
3. what compassionate action followed;
4. one way you can follow that pattern this week.

## Six: Living in the Compassion Place

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CARE WITH COURAGE, WISDOM, AND LIMITS

Knowing yourself is part of changing.

Fear, hesitation, distraction, and indirect communication can all interfere with compassion. So can exhaustion. Compassion fatigue can arrive quietly, especially for caregivers and people who are always expected to be strong.

Balancing self-care with healthy boundaries is real work. Rest is not a betrayal of the people we love. Asking for help is not weakness. A sustainable life of service needs sleep, truthful relationships, spiritual renewal, professional support when needed, and room to be a person rather than a solution to everybody else's crisis.

### Compassion in action

My own compassion in action led me to create Family Keepers With Extended Care, a nonprofit honoring my mother and advocating for caregivers. That work comes from a simple conviction: people who care for others deserve care too.

The world is full of people who are overwhelmed, grieving, ill, isolated, or burned out. We cannot meet every need. We can still become dependable in the place where we have been planted.



### **Pour the cup: build a boundary plan**

Complete these sentences:

- I can reliably offer ...
- I cannot safely take responsibility for ...
- When I am overwhelmed, I will ask ...
- A sign that I need rest is ...
- One professional or community resource I can share is ...

Compassion is strongest when honesty and care travel together.

# In Closing

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The transformative power of compassion is that it encourages the giver, the receiver, and the people watching. From that shared courage, a more caring world becomes possible - if we do the work.

Share this book or its message with someone today. In less than a minute, you can make a loved one feel seen again.

*Keep on giving. Keep on being.*

## Further reading

- *Compassionomics* - Stephen Trzeciak, MD, and Anthony Mazzairelli, MD
- *Self-Compassion* - Kristin Neff, PhD
- *Solve for Happy* - Mo Gawdat
- *Let Love Have the Last Word* - Common

# About the Author

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## Pamella Foster-Grear

Pamella Foster-Grear is the founder of A Cup of Compassion, a movement dedicated to helping individuals and families live with purpose, lead with compassion, and leave a meaningful legacy for generations to come.

For more than three decades, Pamella has served her community through nonprofit leadership, family advocacy, caregiving support, business development, and educational outreach. Her life's work is centered on one belief: compassion should not end with today; it should become tomorrow's inheritance.

As an author, speaker, and educator, Pamella teaches that legacy is more than financial wealth. It is the intentional passing down of love, wisdom, faith, family values, assets, and opportunity. Through writing, workshops, and educational resources, she encourages families to prepare with purpose, have the necessary conversations, and create the documents that preserve relationships and generational wealth.

Pamella believes every family deserves more than memories. They deserve a roadmap that protects what generations have worked to build.

## Continue the conversation

Look for **A Cup of Compassion** on YouTube and podcast platforms, and follow the work of:

- Family Keepers With Extended Care - caregiver advocacy
- Vibranium Health & Services
- Pam Grear Publishing LLC

**BUILD IT. DOCUMENT IT. PASS IT ON.**

*Keep on giving. Keep on being. Blessings.*